



b. 1961 · Harvard Law professor; founder of Creative Commons.

"Code is law; licences are choices."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Lessig argues that in a digital world 'code is law' — software architecture regulates behaviour as powerfully as legal rules — and that licensing is therefore a design choice with public consequences.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A constitutional and cyberlaw scholar, he founded Creative Commons to give creators flexible alternatives to default copyright.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the licensing reasoning behind Unit 4's Licensing Models Map and Open-Source Compliance Ladder.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His ideas operationalise as treating licence choice as a deliberate strategic and ethical decision, especially where AI code inherits training-data obligations.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The 'code is law' thesis can understate the continuing force of formal law and markets, and licensing alone cannot resolve AI's IP questions.

ENDURING IMPACT

Lessig shaped digital-rights and open-licensing movements; Creative Commons licences are used across millions of works.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Jyh-An Lee et al. · Giant 16

Hamilton Helmer · Giant 17

Peter Thiel · Giant 18

Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright · Giant 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Lessig, L. (1999) Code and Other Laws of Cyberspace. New York: Basic Books.

Lessig, L. (2004) Free Culture. New York: Penguin.